BON Appetit Korea – Store #1 Plan: Sindang

A compact first store in Seoul, run as a pilot

October 2026 · All amounts are estimates in KRW (USD 1 = KRW 1,331.4, 16 Oct 2026). VAT not included unless stated.

Dear BON Appetit Team,

We would like to propose Sindang, in central Seoul, as the location of BON Appetit's first store in Korea. The store would sit inside Shin Jungang Market, the first market to be rebuilt under Seoul's “Design Innovation Traditional Market” programme, a flagship project of the Seoul city government.

We plan store #1 as a compact store with a pilot character: low fixed costs, a counter kitchen facing the market lane, and a strong focus on takeaway and delivery. It lets us learn what Korean customers like before we grow, while keeping the investment small.

Because Sindang is less known to visitors than other parts of Seoul, this plan first introduces the neighbourhood and the market redesign, with the city's plans and a comparison with Gwangjang Market, Seoul's best-known food market. It then covers the site, our costs and how we will measure the first months.

KRW 10M
Deposit (returned at the end of the lease)

KRW 1.3M
Monthly rent

≈ KRW 107M
Total funds needed, incl. deposit and 3 months of costs (before any key money)

55–58
Tacos a day to break even

At a glance

Location	Toegye-ro 85-gil 37, Jung-gu, Seoul: inside Shin Jungang Market by Sindang Station (Lines 2 and 6). One stop to Dongdaemun Design Plaza (DDP).
Space	About 33 m² (10 pyeong) on the ground floor, inside the covered market lane, plus the area in front of the shop. A small restaurant operates there today.
Lease	Deposit KRW 10M, rent KRW 1.3M a month. Key money (if any) to be confirmed.
Layout	Inside: half kitchen with the order counter, where guests watch their taco being made, and half seating (about 12 seats). In front: outdoor tables (about 24 seats) for the evening night-market programme. Takeaway and delivery.
Interior	Minimal exposed, vintage style.
Hours	11:00–23:00. Later closing on Friday and Saturday will be tested.
Budget	About KRW 107M (USD 81k) in total, including the deposit and three months of running costs, before any key money.
The market	Seoul's “Design Innovation Traditional Market No. 1”: KRW 18.7 billion redesign, ground broken on 22 Sep 2026, completion targeted for mid-2027.
Next step	Once the pilot works, a second store in a nightlife area for late-night trade.

Sindang: a neighbourhood guide

2 + 6	1 stop	+673%	45%
Subway lines at Sindang Station	to DDP on Line 2	Small-pub card spending in 5 years	Single-person households in Sindang-dong

Where it is. Sindang is in Jung-gu, the historic centre of Seoul, about 1 km east of Dongdaemun Design Plaza (DDP). Sindang Station is a transfer station on Lines 2 and 6: one stop to DDP, four stops to Euljiro (near Myeong-dong) and five stops on Line 6 to Itaewon.

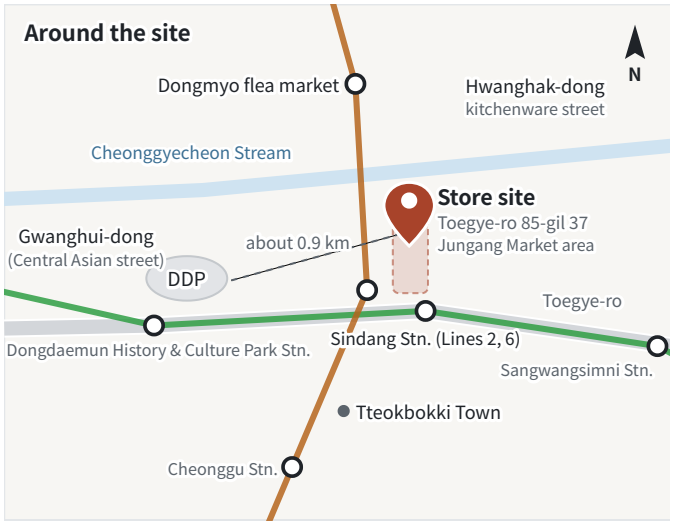
A bit of history. The name comes from the shrines (sindang) that stood outside Gwanghuimun Gate in the Joseon era. Since the 1970s the area has been known for its tteokbokki alley (spicy rice cakes) and for its large traditional market, famous for grilled tripe (gopchang) and fresh produce. Just north is Hwanghak-dong, Seoul's kitchen-equipment street, next to the Dongmyo flea market.

"Hipdang-dong". Young Koreans now call the area "Hipdang-dong" (hip + Sindang-dong). Small bars and restaurants have opened in old market buildings and side streets, more than 40 in 2023 alone. Card spending at small pubs in the area grew 673% over five years (KB Kookmin Card, 2024). Foreign guests are increasing as well: one well-known bar owner told Korea JoongAng Daily (2024) that about 40% of weekday guests are foreigners.

Who lives here. Sindang-dong has about 63,000 residents in 32,000 households, and 45% of households are single-person homes, a good base for delivery and takeaway. The Dongdaemun and Euljiro business areas are within delivery range.

Tourism. Korea welcomed a record 18.9 million foreign visitors in 2025, and about 20.4 million are forecast for 2026. Dongdaemun (DDP) is one of the main tourist areas of Seoul and is one stop away.





Simplified maps. Station and place positions are approximate.

Sources: KB Kookmin Card business-area report (2024); Korea JoongAng Daily (2024); Korea Times (2024); resident statistics, June 2026; Korea tourism statistics for 2025; Yanolja Research forecast for 2026.

Shin Jungang Market redesign: “Roof Wave”

Shin Jungang Market (opened in 1946) is a covered market lane about 275 m long next to Sindang Station. In September 2026 Seoul started rebuilding it as the first project of its “Design Innovation Traditional Market” programme. Mayor Oh Se-hoon calls it “Seoul's No. 1 Design Innovation Traditional Market”, and the city's stated aim is to turn it into “a second Gwangjang Market” that visitors from Korea and abroad seek out.



Rendering of the new market entrance



Rendering of the lane under the daylight timber roof, with stepped seating



Rendering of the new roof over the market lane

Images: Seoul Metropolitan Government project images released with the redesign.

The project in detail



Programme	Seoul Metropolitan Government, “Design Innovation Traditional Market”, project No. 1 and the first to start construction. Similar projects are planned at Namdaemun, Cheongnyangni and Tongin markets.
Budget	About KRW 18.7 billion in total (Sep 2026); arcade works about KRW 15.4 billion (Apr 2026)
Design	“Roof Wave”, chosen in a design competition. The old arcade is replaced by a gable-shaped timber roof that lets in daylight, over a lane about 275 m long (4,095 m^2). Benchmark: Barcelona's Santa Caterina Market, whose wave-shaped roof made the market a tourist sight.
Other works	Gateway-style “open roofs” at the entrances of 16 side alleys; stepped seating where visitors can stay; overhead power cables tidied; a direct indoor route from Sindang Station and a new public parking tower nearby.
Schedule	Ground-breaking 22 Sep 2026. Completion is targeted for mid-2027 (June 2027 in most reports; one report says August). Works may be done section by section, in at least four sections, to keep shops open.
City support	The city plans to make the market the hub of a Dongdaemun–Sindang night-tourism and food belt linking DDP, Hipdang-dong, the tteokbokki alley and Gwanghui-dong (Central Asian street), alongside local-business support programmes.
Night programme	Jung-gu district and the merchants' associations run a night “yajang” (outdoor tables) programme from 18:00 to 23:00, opened on 18 Sep 2026 with 34 shops in this market. Food is cooked indoors and served outside.



Ground-breaking ceremony of “Roof Wave”, Seoul's Design Innovation Traditional Market No. 1 (22 Sep 2026) · Photo: press coverage of the ground-breaking ceremony.

Sources: Dailian, Kyunghyang Shinmun, News1, Discovery News, Asia Today (22 Sep 2026); Herald Business and Dailian (Apr 2026); Seoul Shinmun (21 Sep 2026); Bizhankook (2026); Herald Business (Jan 2026, parking tower); Jung-gu News and eToday (Sep 2026, night programme); Seoul Media Hub (Namdaemun); Herald Business (Mar 2026, Cheongnyangni).

Outlook: where the market is heading

We expect Shin Jungang Market to become much better known after the redesign. Five reasons:

1. **The city's showcase project**
   It is the first of Seoul's Design Innovation Traditional Markets to start construction, and the mayor calls it "Seoul's No. 1". Mayor Oh Se-hoon, who launched the programme, was re-elected in June 2026 for a term to 2030, so we expect continued promotion. Namdaemun, Cheongnyangni and Tongin markets follow, with Shin Jungang as the first example.

2. **A clear tourism role**
   Seoul's stated goal is "a second Gwangjang Market" for Korean and foreign visitors, rebranded around food, culture and tourism, and the hub of a Dongdaemun–Sindang night-tourism belt with DDP, Hipdang-dong, the tteokbokki alley and Gwanghui-dong.

3. **A building people come to see**
   Like Santa Caterina in Barcelona, the new daylight timber roof, open alley gateways and stepped seating are designed to make the market itself a sight, and to make visitors stay longer. A direct indoor route from Sindang Station and a parking tower make it easier to reach.

4. **Momentum on the ground**
   Hipdang-dong is one of Seoul's fastest-growing food and drink areas (small-pub card spending +673% in five years), and the district opened a night yajang programme in the market in September 2026.

5. **More visitors, looking for new places**
   Korea had a record 18.9 million foreign visitors in 2025, with about 20.4 million forecast for 2026. Press reports show visitors increasingly looking for markets beyond Gwangjang, which they now see as crowded and expensive.

What could slow it down

- Construction until mid-2027, possibly section by section. Parts of the market will look like a building site for months.
- A new roof alone does not guarantee more trade; earlier market upgrades in Korea had mixed results. Success depends on content: food, events, night programmes and good service.
- Prices and service must stay fair. Gwangjang Market shows how quickly overpricing stories can hurt a market's image.

Our view

Joining now, before the redesign is finished, gives BON Appetit low entry costs and the chance to become one of the market's signature new foods as the redesign brings in visitors. We will time the lease start and fit-out with the works in front of our store.

Sources: Dailian (22 Sep 2026, mayor's remarks); Herald Business (Apr 2026); Newsis (Jun 2026, election); Yanolja Research (2026 forecast); Money Today (May 2026); Daum/News reports on Gwangjang Market (2026); Korea Citation Index study on market arcades.

Comparison with Gwangjang Market

Gwangjang Market is Seoul's best-known food market and the model Seoul names for Shin Jungang. The two markets are about 2 km apart, on either side of DDP.

	Gwangjang Market	Shin Jungang Market
Founded	1905, one of Korea's oldest permanent markets	1946
Location	Jongno 5-ga, by Cheonggyecheon Stream, west of DDP	Sindang Station (Lines 2 and 6), one stop east of DDP
Known for	Bindaetteok (mung-bean pancakes), mayak gimbap, yukhoe; featured on Netflix's "Street Food: Asia" (2019)	Gopchang (grilled tripe) alley and fresh produce; next to Hipdang-dong's bars and the tteokbokki alley
Visitors	A must-visit for foreign tourists; at some popular stalls foreigners are said to make up 50–70% of customers	Mostly local shoppers and young Koreans today; foreign visitors rising
Stage	Mature and very crowded	Being rebuilt ("Roof Wave", completion mid-2027); the city aims to make it "a second Gwangjang Market"
Recent issues	Repeated overpricing stories (2023–2026); the district now uses mystery shoppers and a stall real-name system; some foreign visitors say they will try other markets	Construction until mid-2027; needs to build its own identity
For a new food brand	Highest footfall, but crowded, scarce and costly space, and a brand tied to the market's image	Lower entry cost, early-mover position, growth together with the redesign

What we take from Gwangjang

- Clear printed prices in Korean and English, card and mobile payment, and the same portion every time.
- Serve locals as well as tourists, so the store does not depend on tourist flows alone.
- Keep the open kitchen clean and visible; in a market, hygiene is part of the brand.

Sources: Seoul Media Hub and Samsung Newsroom (Gwangjang history); Segye Ilbo (2026, Netflix and tourism); Korea Tourism News (share of foreign customers); The Fact, Money Today and Herald Business (2025–2026, overpricing and district measures); Daum News (2026, foreign visitors' reactions).

The site



Storefront in the covered market lane, next to a fried-chicken shop



Today the kitchen equipment stands in front of the shop; in our plan this area becomes evening outdoor seating



Current kitchen equipment facing the market lane; the kitchen will move inside



Dining room today; half becomes the kitchen, half stays seating

Photos: listing photos from the local broker (Hanyang Leaps Realty). Contact details on the current tenant's sign are blurred.

Address	Toegye-ro 85-gil 37 (Hwanghak-dong), Jung-gu, Seoul: inside the market lane near Sindang Station. Its exact position within the redesign area will be confirmed with the project office.
Size	About 33 m² (10 pyeong) inside, ground floor, plus the area in front of the shop
Today	A small Korean restaurant. Its kitchen equipment (gas range, sink, exhaust duct, freezer) stands in front of the shop, facing the lane; the inside is a small dining room.
Lease	Deposit KRW 10M; rent KRW 1.3M a month; key money to be confirmed. Korean law lets the tenant renew for up to 10 years, with each rent increase capped at 5%.

Our layout

- Inside, half the space (about 16 m²) becomes the kitchen with the order counter: guests choose fillings and watch their taco being grilled, as in Bali.
- The other half is seating: about 3 tables, 12 seats, with self-service.
- The area in front, where the kitchen equipment stands today, becomes outdoor seating (about 6 tables, 24 seats) for the district's evening night-market programme. A pickup window faces the lane for takeaway and delivery riders.
- Interior: minimal exposed, vintage style, which keeps the fit-out cost low.

Operating plan and costs

Hours	11:00–23:00, every day. Outdoor tables in the evening during the night-market programme. We will test later closing on Friday and Saturday.
Staff	2 people at lunch, 1 in the afternoon, 2 in the evening, plus 1 on busy outdoor-table nights. The owner is based 2 minutes' walk away.
Kitchen	Inside, about 16 m^2: two contact grills (a third if needed), a gas fryer, a topping display fridge and a cheese-sauce warmer. New hood and exhaust duct; an electricity upgrade to about 12 kW is likely. We will confirm both.
Sales mix (plan)	Dine-in (inside and outdoor) about 40%, takeaway about 20%, delivery about 40%. Average taco KRW 13,500 (to be set with you).

Startup investment (base case)

Item	KRW	USD
Security deposit (returned at the end of the lease)	10.0M	8k
Lease costs (broker fee, rent during fit-out)	2.5M	2k
Fit-out (kitchen moved inside: hood, duct, waterproofing, hygienic finish; minimal exposed/vintage dining; pickup window; gas, electricity, air-conditioning)	19.8M	15k
Kitchen equipment	8.8M	7k
Signage, indoor and outdoor furniture, IT	7.2M	5k
Opening stock, sauce import, permits and training	9.0M	7k
Opening marketing	3.5M	3k
Contingency (12.5%)	4.5M	3k
Subtotal: startup investment	**65.3M**	**49k**
Working capital, 3 months of fixed costs	42.0M	32k
Total funds needed	**107.3M**	**81k**
Key money to the current tenant, if any (not included)		to be confirmed

Range before key money: about KRW 77M–157M. With key money of KRW 15M the total would be about KRW 122M; with KRW 35M, about KRW 142M. The money actually spent (excluding deposit and working capital) is about KRW 55M in the base case.

Monthly fixed costs

Item	KRW / month
Rent	1.3M
Market management fee and association dues (estimate)	0.2M
Staff (about 24 staff hours a day, incl. a shift-lead allowance)	10.9M
Utilities	0.9M
Other (accounting, insurance, POS, delivery-app ads)	0.7M
Total	**≈ 14.0M**

Break-even

About 55 tacos a day (about KRW 28M of sales a month, incl. VAT) in the outdoor-table season, and about 58 a day (about KRW 30M) in winter without outdoor tables. For example: 12 guests inside, 15 at the outdoor tables on night-market days, 11 takeaway and 14 delivery orders. Average ticket: KRW 16,000 inside, KRW 19,000 at outdoor tables (with drinks), KRW 18,000 per takeaway order, KRW 26,000 per delivery order. Royalty is not included.

How we will measure the pilot

What we measure	Tacos sold per day, sales by channel (inside, outdoor tables, takeaway, delivery), repeat customers, delivery-app ratings, food cost, and customers' reaction to prices.
Month 3 review	Target: at least 40 tacos a day, delivery rating 4.7 or higher, food cost 35% or lower. If we are below target, we adjust menu, prices and channels.
Month 6 review	Target: around break-even (about 55–58 tacos a day). At that point we start looking for a second store in earnest.
Late-night store	A second store in a nightlife area. We will count foot traffic on Friday and Saturday nights (22:00–04:00) at candidate sites and compare them with you.

Risks and how we will handle them

Risk	How we will handle it
Market works until mid-2027 (hoarding, dust, fewer visitors)	Link the lease start and fit-out to the works schedule for our section; right to cancel if completion slips; no opening in the middle of the works.
Kitchen moves inside: new hood and exhaust route	Agree the duct route with the landlord and the project office in writing before signing.
Electricity for the grills (about 12 kW needed)	Check the current contract; the gas fryer lowers the load; the upgrade is in the budget.
Outdoor tables depend on the district's night programme (18:00–23:00) and the merchants' association; daytime use of the lane may not be allowed	Confirm the rules in writing; the plan counts outdoor seats only in the evening and in the warm season.
Winter months without outdoor tables	Push takeaway and delivery; the plan is close to break-even in winter.
Market shoppers may find the price high	Test prices and portion sizes in the first months, with your guidance.
Rent after the redesign	By law, renewals are possible for up to 10 years, and each rent increase is capped at 5%.
Key money, licence and building use	Confirm the current restaurant licence type, building use and any key money before signing.

Questions for you

1. Does a compact first store (about 33 m^2, about 12 seats inside plus evening outdoor tables) fit your brand standards?
2. What is the minimum equipment set for a kitchen of about 16 m^2? Are two contact grills and a gas fryer acceptable?
3. Is a minimal exposed, vintage interior acceptable? Do you have signage guidelines for a unit inside a market lane?
4. Roughly what share of Bali sales comes after midnight, and how is it split between dine-in, takeaway and delivery?
5. How many staff do you have per shift in Bali?
6. Do you have smaller or lower-priced items, or drinks pairings, that could suit market shoppers and night-market guests?
7. Can we discuss commercial terms that suit a pilot-format first store?

We would be happy to go through this plan on a video call. Thank you again for your support.